

SAKINA'S KISS
by Vivek Shanbhag (translated by Srinath Perur)
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SRINATH PERUR

Sometimes, writers are truly found in translation. A proliferation in translations of vernacular texts in the past decade has allowed many regional Indian writers to be discovered by a wider audience—occasionally gaining international recognition as well. The case of Kannada novelist, short-story writer and playwright Vivek Shanbhag is special in that it is underpinned by a close partnership with his translator, Srinath Perur, an accomplished writer in his own right.

They first tasted success with *Ghachar Ghochar*. Perur's 2015 translation brought international acclaim to Shanbhag's work. *Ghachar Ghochar* was included by *The New York Times* in its listing of the best books of 2017. It was a finalist for the Los Angeles Times Book Prize and the International Dublin Literary Award. And Srinath Perur bagged the Sahitya Akademi Prize for Translation in the English section in 2020 for the book.

Sakina's Kiss, a translation of Shanbhag's Kannada novel *Sakinala Muttu*, which was published in 2021, rides on those accolades and attendant expectations. Shanbhag's mother tongue is Konkani, but he writes in Kannada. He is a prolific writer, having penned nine works of fiction and three plays. He also used to be editor of the literary

BOOKS

Stranger Than Truth

Manjula Padmanabhan's *Stolen Hours and Other Curiosities* brings all her science fiction stories together in one place

In the Author's Note to *Stolen Hours and Other Curiosities*–Manjula Padmanabhan's career-spanning science fiction anthology–she writes about what the genre means to her. "Writing SF is a way of celebrating the 'other-ing' that I experienced as a young person. Instead of travelling to other countries, I can explore alternate states of consciousness, timelines, body types, species, genders, dimensions." There are 25 stories in total, with the oldest ('A Government of India Undertaking') written in 1984 and the most recent one ('Octobaby') written shortly before publication. Together, they're a reminder of the 70-year-old Padmanabhan's stature as one of the most versatile and inventive Indian writers of her generation–not to mention, one of the pioneers of South Asian science fiction.

"This collection has been in the works for a while," Padmanabhan says. "New stories would be published every few years and I'd keep thinking about a consolidated volume of my science fiction. Eventually, it was the pandemic that set the wheels in motion. It was a lull period for writers and publishers and during a lull you can do the things you've been putting off."

Stolen Hours shows off Padmanabhan's range within the science fiction genre. 'Talkers' is an extended, crystalline joke about a race of winged aliens bestowing humanity with the gift of speech. The hugely enjoyable 'Feast' is about a European vampire visiting Delhi, enthralled with "the squishy soft bodies pressed against him on all sides" at places like the Nizamuddin Dargah and Palika Bazaar. The playful, allegorical 'India 2099' follows an Indian Rip Van Winkle, the editor of a newsmagazine, as he